

Session 34: Jonah's Prayer: Oddities and Observations

Key Takeaways

- The image of a prophet composing a poem in the belly of a beast is odd, but so is the prayer's content. Why is it a thanksgiving for deliverance instead of a confession of guilt or a plea to be released from the fish?
- When the text doesn't give clear answers, it's an invitation for us to meditate on the story and author's message.

Jonah's Prayer: Translation and Literary Design of Jonah 2:2-9

A

² I called out from my distress **to Yahweh** ,
and he answered me.

From the belly of the grave I shouted for help,
and you heard my voice.

B

³ **And you cast me to the deep, to the heart of the seas** .
And **a river surrounded me** .
All your waves and breakers passed over me.

C

⁴ And I said: "I am banished from before your eyes.
However, I will continue to gaze **to your holy temple** ."

B'

⁵ The waters encircled me up to the neck.
The deep surrounded me,
kelp wrapped to my head.

⁶ To the bases of the mountains I went down.
The underworld, its bars around me forever,
but you raised up my life from the pit, Yahweh my God .

C'

⁷ When my being was fainting within me,
I remembered Yahweh,

and my prayer came to you
to your holy temple.

A'

⁸ Those who keep idols of worthlessness
forsake the covenant love shown them

⁹ but I, with a voice of thanksgiving, I will sacrifice **to you**.
What I have vowed I will pay in full.

Rescue belongs **to Yahweh** !

Jonah 2:2-9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

The prayer begins and ends (A and A') with Jonah's orientation "to Yahweh," first crying out from his distress, and then vowing allegiance after his deliverance. Inside of this is Yahweh's action of first casting him into the seas (B), which is reversed in B' as God draws him up from the pit. Matched with the descent is his final hopeful glance up to Yahweh's temple (C), which is matched by his prayer ascending to Yahweh's temple (C'), which leads to his deliverance.

Jonah's descent is marked in two stages. In B, Jonah is sinking into the deep waters, while in B', he has hit bottom and reached the underworld. It is precisely at this moment that his descent converts into an ascent from the pit.

Notice how B begins with Yahweh's initiative in casting him down into the deep, but then the conclusion of B' makes Yahweh's action central in raising him up from the pit. Jonah's double descent is matched by a twin upward orientation. In C, all he can manage is to look to God's temple. But after he is assured of deliverance in C', he can know that his prayer has actually ascended to God's temple.

"The stages of descent in the poem are described with almost geographical exactitude: at first the 'flood,' the breakers and waves pass over him; he descends further to the base of the mountains till the very earth closes over him. Every other description of 'danger from the waters' in the book of Psalms consists of a series of synonymous phrases which are interchangeable, but no other examples of such a prolonged, consecutive descent are described ... It displays essentially a narrative technique that has organized the symbolic terminology of the 'underworld' into a coherent pattern of the continuing descent."

Magonet, Jonathan (1983). [*Form and Meaning: Studies in Literary Techniques in the Book of Jonah*](#). Almond Press. 40-41.

Metaphorical Imagery of the Poem

Notice how all of the various metaphors for death in biblical poetry have been associated.

Images of Death in 2:3

- “From the belly of Sheol”: the grave in the underworld
- “The deep” (Heb. *metsulah*): the depths of the open oceans
- “The heart of the seas”: the depths of the open oceans
- “A river”: the ocean currents

Images of Death in 2:5

- “The waters”: general term for rivers, oceans, or underworld waters
- “The deep”: the waters under the earth
- “Kelp”: the vegetation at the bottom of the sea
- “The bases of the mountains” + “the underworld”: the base/bottom of the cosmic dome

Reflection Question

What strikes you as odd in Jonah’s poem?